posing pictures of his face with the slogan *'Sansad wich vi Bhagwant Mann'* (Mann in Parliament too)—came a cropper. The angry farmers make it a point to remind Mann of his pre-2022 election commitment of procuring crops at the minimum support price (MSP) even if the central agencies failed to do so. But in some respite to him, most farm unions have kept their communication channels open and suspended blockades, giving him leeway to travel to New Delhi and meet Union ministers. The delays, though, are drying up their options as well.

The situation has grown more complex for Mann as his cabinet colleagues, party legislators and bureaucrats have reached out to the AAP leadership over the past month with complaints about inefficiencies in his administration. Although Mann loyalists term it a routine exercise, his rivals within the party—who had already been leaking their conversations with top leaders, including national convenor Arvind Kejriwal—are calling it the "beginning of corrections". They want a younger Hindu face or a Jat woman leader to replace Mann as the Punjab unit chief. "A lot needs to be done to face the electorate with confidence...without rhetoric," says a senior state leader, who has persistently lobbied against Mann.

The impact of these political manoeuvrings is becoming apparent with each passing day. In mid-October, as the party's official social media handles released the list of candidates for the assembly bypolls in Punjab, seasoned observers noted an unusual two-hour gap before Mann's customary congratulatory message appeared. While the candidate list held no surprises, the delay spoke volumes about the growing undercurrents within the party—fuelling speculation that the AAP high command in Delhi is methodically pruning what they view as excess administrative latitude in Mann's government.

Just days before, in a key reorganisation on October 9, the state government replaced chief secretary Anurag Verma with K.A.P. Sinha, a decision flowing from the party's central command. Soon, two heavyweight advisors—former revenue services officer Arbind Modi, fresh from his stint at the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and Sebastian James, a US-based former economist at the World Bank—were appointed to oversee fiscal management. The state's precarious financial situation demands immediate attention, with debt projected to reach Rs 3.74 lakh crore by the end of this financial year—representing 46 per cent of Punjab's gross domestic product (GDP). Despite improved GST collections and various revenue-enhancement initiatives, the state's resources are stretched thin by populist spending, expansive subsidies, mounting freebies, and ballooning salary and pension obligations, leaving minimal fiscal space for development projects. The Centre's cold shoulder to around Rs 1.5 lakh crore bailout package for Punjab, coupled with persistent pressure for expenditure reforms, has only intensified the crisis. The state's reputation as a debt-trapped entity severely hampers AAP's expansion aspirations.

The appointment of Modi and James followed Kejriwal's direct intervention, where he conducted one-on-one reviews with Punjab cabinet ministers in Delhi—notably in the absence of Mann, who at the time was in Punjab. Sources within the cabinet confirmed to INDIA TODAY that Kejriwal not only reviewed their performance but also set explicit targets for the coming year, assuring ministers of his personal oversight—ammunition readily seized upon by the Opposition to take potshots at Mann. "We are not sure who is the CM," quips the leader of the Opposition, Partap Singh Bajwa, "Mann or [his] Delhi bosses?"

IN PUNJAB, AAP HAS THE POLITICAL SPACE AS WELL AS TIME FOR A COURSE CORRECTION AS ITS POSITION REMAINS RELATIVELY SECURE AMID A FRAGMENTED OPPOSITION CAMP



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Mid-term Corrections

Since securing bail in a corruption case mid-September, Kejriwal has intensified his focus on revitalising AAP's prospects in Delhi while simultaneously tightening his grip on Punjab's governance. Having relinquished his chief ministerial duties in Delhi, he now has more time to concentrate on strengthening the party, especially with the upcoming assembly polls in Delhi and complaints against Mann's "working style" emerging from Punjab. In late September, a mid-term cabinet reshuffle saw five fresh faces—Hardeep Singh Mundian, Barinder Kumar Goyal, Tarunpreet Singh Sond, Ravjot Singh and newly elected Mohinder Bhagat—replacing four ministers—Brahm Shankar Jimpa, Chetan Singh Jouramajra, Anmol Gagan Maan and Balkar Singh. All four were either embroiled in controversies or facing anti-incumbency. Among them, Jouramajra and Anmol Gagan were considered close to Mann. Mann's loyalists maintain that all changes were performance-based and aimed at improving public perception, as part of the party's "Operation Cleanup". The central leadership, they argue, understands that no other state